

THE BACKGROUND BEFORE MARCH 1959

In the 19th century, France conquered Vietnam, Cambodia, and Laos, creating the colony of French Indochina. The French divided Vietnam into three parts: Tonkin, Annam, and Cochin China. Repressing nationalist revolts, the French maintained colonial rule in Vietnam until World War II, when Indochina was occupied by the Japanese. At the war's end, the communist-led Viet Minh declared Vietnam independent, but France strove to retake control of its colony. After prolonged fighting, Viet Minh guerrillas defeated the French in the First Indochina War, inflicting a final humiliation at the battle of Dien Bien Phu. After negotiations at the Geneva Conference, Vietnam became independent as two states, divided by a Demilitarized Zone (DMZ). North Vietnam was under communist rule, while South Vietnam was backed by the United States.